

« I want to help Patna Pirates win a fourth title »

DEVANK DALAL

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In every sport, there occasionally comes a performance that disrupts its status quo. This is even more captivating in team sports when an athlete does something so spectacular that it changes the perception of the entire team.

In this season of the Pro Kabaddi League, Patna Pirates' Devank Dalal has been that player, whose brilliance has almost single-handedly elevated the team's standing.

Playing only his eighth game in the PKL, the young raider from Singhpura Khurd village in the Rohtak district of Haryana had the Hyderabad crowd chanting his name when he single-handedly led the Patna Pirates to an improbable victory against the Tamil Thalaivas on October 25.

It was the Pirates' first win of the season, and Devank scored a staggering 25 points as his team pulled off a comeback victory.

"It was all about the team, and I thought someone had to step up. I never thought, even in my wildest dreams, that I'd score 25 points. It was my day. On another day, another player will step up. But it is important for us to play together, and that's how we can win games,"

Devank told *Sportstar*.

Since that breakthrough performance, Devank has become the star of the season. Leading the scoring charts with 233 raid points from 18 matches at an average of 12.94 points per match, the 24-year-old has been front and centre of the Pirates' bid for a spot in the playoffs (as of December 16).

"Currently, I have three stars on my shirt this year. But when we play next year, I want to have four stars. I want to help Patna win a fourth title," he added.

Devank defies the conventional mould of a raider. His understated approach belies a multifaceted skill set and an uncanny game sense. He possesses a potent blend of power, height, speed, and deceptive agility.

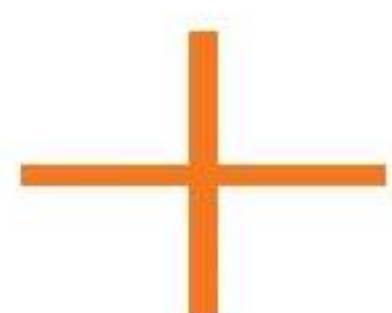
Born into a farming family in Rohtak, Haryana — a region known to produce prolific kabaddi players

— the sport initially served as an escape from studies for Devank, who began training seriously in 2018.

"I never had the patience to sit and study, and when I saw my friends hardly attending classes because of their sports engagements, I thought I too could do the same if I started playing kabaddi after my 10th standard exams."

Two years later, Devank made his way into the Indian Army team through their sports programme, impressing in the trials. He subsequently participated in an inter-services tournament. F

ollowing another strong showing, Devank caught the attention of PKL scouts and was drafted into the Jaipur Pink Panthers through the NYP (New Young Player) programme for the ninth season of



The Pirates have been the most successful raiding team this season, accumulating 438 raid points at an average of 24.33 points with an average of 18.5 successful raids per match.